

fiercest derbies in English football — the Tyne-Wear and the Roses — happen together in the Premier Division for the first time in 22 years.

End of an era, beginning of another

For nearly three decades, club football was enriched by the presence of Carlo Ancelotti.

His dynamism with formations (an aggressive 4-3-3 from his preferred 4-4-2 variant led to Champions League glory with Real Madrid in 2022), the art of sculpting legends like Gianluigi Buffon and Kaka, and chalking out the role of a modern regista in Andrea Pirlo made him one of the greatest managers of all time.

The Italian is now Brazil's coach, as his former ward, Xabi Alonso, looks to fill his big boots at the Spanish capital. However, he won't enjoy the services of midfield talisman Luka Modric, who has moved to AC Milan.

Alonso, a 2010 FIFA World Cup winner, led Bayer Leverkusen to an invincible streak of 51

unbeaten games (42 wins, nine draws) in the 2023-24 season, winning the Bundesliga, DFB-Pokal and DFL-Supercup.

La Liga champion Barcelona, on the other hand, will hope for more magic from its new No. 10 — another feather in the cap of youth sensation Lamine Yamal, who took over Lionel Messi's legendary jersey shortly after his 18th birthday.

The youngster has already won the European Championship with Spain and four major titles with Barcelona before turning 18, but only time will tell if the jersey's reputation weighs too heavily on him.

Among the newly promoted sides, Real Oviedo returned to La Liga after 24 years — a tale of pure dedication and love from two-time Euro winner with Spain, Santi Cazorla. The 40-year-old returned to his boyhood club in 2023, played for minimum salary, and helped it win the playoff final 3-1.

All eyes on the Bavarians

A year after the norm was broken in German top-flight football — Bayer Leverkusen dominated the league and won it without losing a match — the usual script played out last season as Bayern Munich clinched the Bundesliga for the 33rd time in its fabled history.

Heading into the new season, Vincent Kompany's men will again be the team to beat, especially with the addition of explosive winger Diaz in the frontline, whom the Bavarians signed from Premier League champion Liverpool.

While Bayern has an exciting player to look forward to, it will miss the magic of Jamal Musiala, after the player broke his leg in a FIFA Club

A new avatar for the maestro:

Napoli will be bolstered by the exciting midfield duo of Kevin De Bruyne (in pic) — who joined from Manchester City on a free transfer — and Scott McTominay. AP

